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Culture (OWC): [Khoi \(FX13\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1903-1905

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Section Title(S): 3. Name Giving

Occasionally the white man gets a nickname. Thus a Hottentot once remarked of a worthy missionary, remembering gratefully a good deed performed for him by this man with black mutton-chop whiskers, calling him *nũxōgũsōatse, "oh, thou son of a black-cheeked sheep." This was an image that is close to the shepherd and would always be considered a compliment by a Hottentot. (See illustration, p. 263).

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Naming

The Hottentot's marked sense for satire expresses itself freely and happily in teasing names for his own people and for his white masters:

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*//kxa'nsab was the name of a boy with a stomach that stuck out (from *//kxan, to forego evacuating the bowels); *//go'resōnōa'tsoa'b a boy with an awkward posture, "whose neck vertebra was in his buttocks"; *!hoōmxōs, i.e. the "mountain cheeks," was the name of a Negro with fat cheeks; *kxōre'b, i.e. "bag of bones," a thin fellow; *//gaorab was the name of a dirty fellow "who tastes horrible." etc.

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Boys in their adolescence with their mixture of childish and adult characteristics also evoke the mockery of a Hottentot. One such youth in his late adolescence was called *a'ru//gui'b. The word aru means driving the young lambs away from the old animals that go to pasture, while the young ones stay by the hut. The word alludes to the childish features of the boy.

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//gu' i means in the language of the herdsman: a bull calf that actually should be castrated but that still has its testicles; the word alludes to the awakening manhood of the boy.

Indicative of the decline in polygamy is the fact that a man who still enjoyed this luxury was known by the name *a'mikxomaꞤgu'ita'raseb, i.e. as one "who has many (Ꞥgui) wives (tara. s) just as an ostrich (ami. s) has hens."

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The Hottentot find weak points in the bodies of the white men even more easily than in his own. A person who he thinks has too long a neck is called the "necky one," *!ao'xab; another person's 308 mustache hangs over his mouth (ams) as a dog's lips (*//gaꞤbu'b) over its snout and so he is called *//gabuxaa'mi.

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Another is named for the peculiar expression of his eyes for a gecko lizard of the same name, a *Bachydactylus* species, *!na'nigyemũꞤs, another one, because of his stamping gait *!nõ'Ꞥarib, the "heel man." The Hottentots in Kubub called an especially tall man !a'batoma!nao'b, i.e. "he who does not have to climb (!a'ba) on the wagon to load it" (!naꞤo).

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They called another !a'osa/ã'batana's (with a feminine ending) because he lets his head (tana's) hang loosely to one side and dangle with 110 every step, and carries it as though his neck (!aos) were "wet" (/ã i.e. like a soft, flexible juicy flower stalk). His opposite, a man whose pride expressed itself in a perpetual stretching of his backbone, was called "the hollow one" *!nẽꞤb by the men; by the women: */ã'saxã'b, because his penis (xãb) was new (/ãsa) i.e. very potent.

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